

The wax gives under your thumb — no seal any of us knows. Inside: a single sheet of instructions, and folded beneath it, heavier, the thing itself. The letter we are paid to carry, and forbidden to read.

Outside, the city does not know to be afraid. It is Saint Dorothy's day, the last gasp of carnival before the fast — pipes and drums in the streets, masks on half the faces we pass, a child handing out paper roses as if roses grew in February. Good cover, a day like this. A man can wear another face and no one looks twice.

Toruń, the 6th of February, the Year of Our Lord 1454

MESSENGERS,

The sealed letter enclosed with this note is not yours to read. Carry it. Protect it. Deliver it before the eighth bell strikes tonight.

You were paid to do a simple thing. The city has made it complicated. Your original contact is not where he was meant to be. You will need to find another way to the recipient.

Know this: whoever reads that letter, loses it, or delivers it to the wrong hands will answer for it. Not with money. WITH THEIR HANDS. You have been warned once. You will not be warned again.

YOUR PATH BEGINS HERE.

Enclosed: a MAP and a CIPHER SHEET. The map shows marks. Each mark tells you *where to go* — not what you will find. That you must see for yourself.

BEGIN AT THE TRIANGLE. Find it on the map and go there. At each mark:

1. Look around for a DETAIL that matches one of the pictures on the cipher sheet.
2. That picture points you to the NEXT MARK. Go there. Repeat.
3. Record each place you identify in the LEGEND on your map.

Your chain has EXACTLY FOUR STEPS. It ends where our man is waiting.

Beware false trails: if you find yourself going in circles, or returning to a mark already visited, you have strayed — go back to the last mark you are certain of.

When you reach the end, tell our man the FOUR PLACES YOU VISITED, IN ORDER. That is all he needs. After that, you will receive your next instructions.

Tell no one.

So: a letter we cannot read, a road we have to find for ourselves, and a plain promise of what it costs to fail. Whoever wants this carried does not mean for us to enjoy the carrying. The first mark waits on the map. We start walking.